

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Missing Wheel

Grade 4 reading comprehension · Story · 12 points · About 20 minutes

The gym was buzzing on the morning of the fourth-grade science fair. Jada set her solar-powered car on the table and stepped back to admire it. She had spent three weeks building it, and the yellow paint was still shiny.

At the next table, Ben stood with his arms folded, staring at his own car. One of its wheels lay beside it, snapped in two. “I tested it before school,” he mumbled. “It rolled right off the ramp.” He did not look up.

Jada glanced at the clock. The judges would arrive in ten minutes. She opened her toolbox and found the spare wheel she had made, just in case. It was the only one she had. If something went wrong with her car today, she would have nothing to fix it with.

She bit her lip. Then she walked over and held out the wheel. “Here,” she said. “It should fit.”

Ben’s eyes grew wide. “But what if you need it?” “I’ll figure something out,” said Jada, shrugging as if it was no big deal. But her hand trembled a little as she let go.

When the judges came, both cars rolled smoothly down the ramp. One judge nodded and wrote something on her clipboard. Ben grinned so hard that his cheeks must have hurt.

That afternoon, while Jada was packing up, she found a small yellow sticky note inside her toolbox. In Ben’s messy handwriting, it said, “I owe you one wheel. Maybe two.” Underneath, he had drawn a tiny smiling car.

1. How long had Jada spent building her car? (1 point)

2. What happened to Ben’s wheel? (1 point)

3. How did Ben feel at the start of the story? What in the text makes you think so? (2 points)

4. Why do you think Jada bit her lip before she gave Ben the wheel? (2 points)

5. What does the word “trembled” mean in the sentence “her hand trembled a little as she let go”?

(1 point)

6. Jada shrugged “as if it was no big deal.” Do you think it really was no big deal to her? Explain, using evidence from the text. (2 points)

7. What does the sticky note tell you about how Ben felt? How do you know? (2 points)

8. Choose the sentence that best tells the theme of the story. Write its letter. (1 point)

- A. Sharing what you have can help a friend, even when it is hard.
- B. Winning a ribbon is more important than helping the people around you.
- C. Science fairs are always very loud, crowded and full of broken projects.
- D. Every car in a science fair should always come with two spare wheels.

Answer: _____

Writing task: Write a short story about a time someone shared something that was hard to give up.
